

Orthodoxy 201

Intro

- ◆ When Prince Vladimir's emissaries visited the Church of holy wisdom in Constantinople back in the 10th century and attended a worship service, they explained to their leader: "we knew not whether we were in heaven or on earth. One thing we understood, that God was in our midst."
- ◆ The Divine Liturgy is the sacred right service by which the Orthodox Church celebrates the Mystery/Sacrament of the Holy Eucharist, which was instituted by our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ at the Last (or properly known in Orthodox Terminology) Mystical Supper to perpetuate the remembrance of His redemptive work and to establish continuous intimate communion between Himself and His faithful people.
- ◆ Through the Divine Liturgy we remember and celebrate with joy and Thanksgiving the whole Mystery of the Divine economy - God's household plan for the salvation of the world - from creation to the Incarnation and especially the Passion, Resurrection, Glorification and Second Coming of the Son and Word of God.
- ◆ The earliest account of the Mystical Supper is found in Saint Paul's 1st letter to the Corinthians 11: 23-26 10:16-21, followed by accounts in the Synoptic Gospels Matthew 26:26-29, Mark 14:22-25 and Luke 22:17-20. The Gospel according to John does *not* mention the Eucharist in the account of the Mystical Supper but contains a significant brief discourse in Eucharistic terms on the Bread of Life that Jesus gives (John 6:51-58) and the Bread He gives is His own Consecrated Body.
- ◆ At every Divine Liturgy we embrace are embraced by the boundless love of the Triune God
- ◆ At every Divine Liturgy we also meet the Crucified and Risen Christ and are united with Him
- ◆ As previously shared in the subject of the Mysteries/Sacraments on the Holy Eucharist, the Eucharist is the central act of the Church. In and through it the Church actualizes Herself as the Body of Christ. Thus, the whole life of the local community or parish is centered essentially on the weekly celebration of the Eucharist on the Lord's Day that being Sunday.
- ◆ We gather together as God's people to confess our common faith; express our indissoluble unity and love; learn and live another new true way of life; receive the sanctity to bear fruit and experience the

transformation of our being by communing the Lord Christ Sacramentally as members of His Body i.e. the Church.

- ✦ What we do every Sunday when we gather to worship our creator through the Divine Liturgy is we encounter the living God. We take a journey into the Kingdom of heaven and experience the Divine!
- ✦ The story of the Liturgy goes back thousands of years. At the end of our Lord's earthly ministry, just before He was betrayed and was Crucified, He celebrated a Passover meal with His apostles.
- ✦ The Passover meal commemorated the Jewish remembrance of Moses and the Israelites freedom from Egypt and the evil rule of pharaoh. Just as God miraculously broke the chains of the Egyptians and ended the bond of slavery for Israel, in the same way, Jesus, on the night he was betrayed, was preparing to free all of mankind from our bondage to sin and death.
- ✦ The Old Testament Passover story is significant in understanding the Liturgy because we use the same symbol that they used in celebrating their victory...bread. The Israelites were instructed to use unleavened bread on the night of their exile from Egypt *because they did not have the time* to wait for the bread to rise, being that they were on the run.
- ✦ In the liturgy we also use bread with the distinct difference that it is leavened, life-giving risen. As Orthodox Christians we are "no longer on the run" but we stand under the protection of our Risen Lord and Savior Jesus Christ. This is why the portion used to commemorate Christ in the Liturgy has four distinct symbols:
- ✦ **IC XC NI KA**
- ✦ These letters mean Jesus Christ Victorious
- ✦ He is victorious over the power of sin through forgiveness and over the power of death through His life-giving Resurrection.
- ✦ The same portion is also called in Greek the "Amno" which means lamb. As Saint John the Baptist said when he saw Jesus coming *"behold the Lamb of God who takes away the sins of the world"*. Also, foretelling the coming of the Savior, the Prophet Isaiah in the *"like a lamb he was led to the slaughter"* Old Testament wrote" Isaiah 53: 7. Isaiah was speaking of Jesus's Crucifixion. Knowing all of this, isn't it interesting that the Israelites were spared the last plague in Egypt by putting the blood of a lamb above their door in the sign of a cross??? Exodus 12: 7

- ◆ So for us today we are on a journey too.
- ◆ A journey that will take us from the cares, anxieties, worries and concerns of this present life to the glory and splendor of Heaven. A journey that will lead us into the realm of Angels and Saints, into a sphere where all the righteous people who have gone before us come together to worship The Almighty God. This journey will not only take us into the Heavens, but it will also unite us with all the faithful around the world celebrating at our Lord's Holy Table - no matter where in the world we may be located!
- ◆ Through this journey, our gathering here is transformed from a mere human gathering of individuals into the Sacred Body of Christ. During the Divine Liturgy we participate in the saving acts of Jesus Christ as previously mentioned before
- ◆ His Life, His Death, His Resurrection, His Ascension, and His Enthronement in Heaven at the Right Hand of the Father.

Unfortunately...

- ◆ Many people come to Church and never experience something so exciting. In order to experience such a life transforming offering, such a life transforming event such a life transforming Liturgy...we need to remind ourselves that it comes through our efforts and active participation.
- ◆ Sometimes the greatest experiences in our life in fact cost us something
- ◆ *And no I am not just talking finances.*
- ◆ If we want to get something out of the Liturgy then we must be ready to put our whole self, 100% participation, 100% focus, 100% direction, 100% heartfelt prayers of worship into the Liturgy itself.
- ◆ We must come together to offer work to God, this is what worship is... worshipping God with our minds our bodies and our souls.

We Must Remember...

- ◆ That the Divine Liturgy is not a performance that is being done by simply the clergy require or the chanters it should not be seen as they're up there and I'm over here. It is not passive entertainment during which believers sit back and watch what is happening.
- ◆ In fact it is an active dialogue where we communicate together as one body to the living God. The clergy alone should not be doing all the activity. As believers everyone must bring their complete self in active signs of worship. The liturgy as we will soon see and discuss is a dialogue. When the clergy offers

petitions whether it be for peace health or safety etcetera all together must affirm this petition with fervor in saying Lord have mercy.

- ✦ The word liturgy means common work or common action. The Divine Liturgy is the common work of the Orthodox Church. It is the official action of the Church formally gathered together as the chosen People of God.
- ✦ The word Church, as we remember means a gathering or assembly of people specifically chosen and called apart to perform a particular task.
- ✦ The Divine Liturgy is always done on the Lord's Day, which is Sunday, the "day after Sabbath" which is symbolic of the first day of creation and the last day — or as it is called in Holy Tradition, the 8th day of the Kingdom of God.
- ✦ This is the day of Christ's Resurrection from the dead, the day of God's judgement and victory predicted by the prophets, the Day of the Lord.

When Can We Celebrate the Liturgy?

- ✦ As the common action of the People of God, the Divine Liturgy may be celebrated only once on any given day in an Orthodox Christian community.
- ✦ Meaning one Altar Table, one Antimension (will discuss what this is at a later session), one Bishop or Priest
- ✦ All the members of the Church must be gathered with the Clergy at one time. You cannot serve a Divine Liturgy privately/alone.
- ✦ Always everyone, always together. That is why all the petitions and hymns (*except for the Creed*) are recited in the plural. This is the traditional expression of the Orthodox about the Liturgy.
- ✦ The body of the Church. "Now you are the Body of Christ, and members individually." 1 Cor 12:27
- ✦ Because of this nature The Divine Liturgy can never be served alone or just for some and not for others, but "in all and for all".
- ✦ It may never be served merely for some private purposes or for some very particular purposes or projects.
- ✦ Thus there may be and usually are special petitions at the Divine Liturgy for the sick or the departed, or for some very particular purpose or events, - Covid prayers, fire, disasters, etc. - but there is never a

Divine Liturgy which is done exclusively for private individuals or specific isolated purposes or intentions.

- ◆ Because the Divine Liturgy exists for no other reason than to be the official all-inclusive act of prayer, worship, teaching and communion of the entire Church in Heaven (Church Triumphant) and on earth (Church Militant)
- ◆ The Divine Liturgy is not an act of personal piety. *See the Publican and the Pharisee.*
- ◆ It is not a prayer service. It is not merely one of the Mysteries/Sacraments. The Divine Liturgy is the ONE COMMON MYSTERY of the very being of the Church Herself. It is the one Mystical/Sacramental manifestation of the essence of the Church as the Community of God in Heaven and on Earth. It is the one unique Sacramental revelation of the Church as the Mystical Body and Bride of Christ.

The Spirit of the Divine Liturgy

- ◆ As the central Mystical action of the whole church, the Divine Liturgy is always Resurrectional in Spirit. It is always the manifestation to His people of the Risen Christ. It is always an outpouring of the Life Creating Spirit.
- ◆ The Divine Liturgy is therefore never mournful or penitential. It is never the expression of darkness and death of this world. It is always the expression and the experience of the Eternal Life of the Kingdom of the Blessed Trinity.
- ◆ The Divine Liturgy celebrated by the Orthodox
- ◆ Church is called the Liturgy of St. John Chrysostom. It is a shorter Liturgy (offering prayers) than the so-called Liturgy of St. Basil the Great which is used only ten times during the Church year: January 1, the feast of St. Basil; on the five Sundays of Great Lent; on the eve of Christmas and Theophany; on the former feasts when they occur on Sunday or Monday; on Holy Thursday; and on Holy Saturday Morning.
- ◆ These two Liturgies probably received their present form after the ninth century. They were not written *exactly* as they now stand by the saints whose names they carry are attributed to. The Eucharistic prayers were formulated as early as the fourth and fifth centuries when these saints lived and worked in the Church.
- ◆ The Divine Liturgy has two main parts. The first part is the gathering, called the Synaxis. It has its origin in the synagogue gathering of the OT, and is centered in the proclamation and mediation of the Word of God. The second part of the Liturgy is the Eucharistic Sacrifice. It has its origin in the OT Temple

worship, the priestly sacrifices of the people of God; and in the central saving event of the OT, the Passover (Pascha in Greek).

- ✦ In the NT, Jesus Christ – The Living Word of God and it is the Christian Gospel and Apostolic writings which are proclaimed and meditated at the first part of the Divine Liturgy. The central saving event is the One Perfect, Eternal and all-sufficient Sacrifice of Jesus Christ, the One Great High Priest who is also the Lamb of God - slain for the salvation of the world. As discussed before, The New Passover.
- ✦ For centuries it was practice of the Church to admit all persons to the first part of the Divine Liturgy, while reserving the second part strictly for those who were formally committed to Christ through Baptism and Chrismation in the Church. Non-baptized persons were not permitted even to witness the offering and receiving of Holy Communion by the faithful Christians.
- ✦ Thus, the first part of the Liturgy came to be called the Liturgy of the Catechumens, that is, the Liturgy of those who were receiving instructions in the Christian faith in order to become members of the Church through Baptism and Chrismation.
- ✦ The second part of the Liturgy came to be called the Liturgy of the Faithful.
- ✦ General practice that non-Orthodox are allowed to stay, pray and celebrate yet Holy Communion is still reserved for Baptized/Chrismated Orthodox Christians that are prepared to receive.
- ✦ It must be stated, that **“no one is worthy”** to receive Holy Communion even though is Orthodox. It is only by the Grace of the Holy Spirit, through confession that one can technically receive Holy Communion.
- ✦ It should also be noted that the Divine Liturgy is not a reenactment. For example, the prothesis (preparation of the gifts) stands for Christ’s Birth; the Small Entrance for the beginning of His public ministry, the Gospel for His preaching, the Great Entrance for Palm Sunday, etc.
- ✦ Some also say the Divine Liturgy is boring. All we do is the same thing every week. The reality is that the Liturgy is a living expression of our Worship to Jesus Christ.
- ✦ Unlike in other Christian denominations, where one has to say that the *“service today was either good or bad”*, in the Orthodox Church the Divine Liturgy is about not making you feel good, but rather drawing your attention to Christ who at each Divine Liturgy Sacrifices Himself, the Lamb of God for the remission of our sins.

Prothesis

- ✦ Before the actual beginning of the Divine Liturgy, the priest enters the Church with special prayers, and puts on His Liturgical Vestments. He then goes to the table of oblation to prepare the bread and wine for Holy Communion. This part of the preparation for The Divine Liturgy is called the “Prothesis or Proskomede” which means preparation.
- ✦ In its present form, the prothesis probably dates from the 14th century.
- ✦ When a Bishop is Celebrating the DL the Prothesis is done just before the offertory procession called the Great Entrance. Otherwise it is done before the beginning of the Liturgy of the Word.
- ✦ At the Prothesis the priest first cuts a large cube of bread from the loaf, traditionally called the *prophoro*, which means “*the offering*”. This cube of bread is called “the Lamb”. It stands for Christ, the Bread of life... which came down from heaven” the “Lamb of God who takes away the sins of the world. (John 3:29, 6:32-35)
- ✦ While the priest is cutting the Lamb from the *prophoro* bread, he recites verses from the prophesy of Isaiah: “He was led as a lamb to the slaughter...” (Isaiah 53:7-8).
- ✦ He cuts the lamb so that the seal is on the top, in the center. The seal is a square with the symbols of Jesus Christ IC XC on the top and the Victor NI KA on the bottom.
- ✦ The lamb is then cut from the bottom in the sign of a cross so that it can be easily broken into 4 pieces at the time of Holy Communion in the Liturgy. The priest also symbolically pierces the side of the lamb with the liturgical knife, traditionally called “the spear” receiving the words of John 19:34-35.
- ✦ Also having poured wine mixed with water into the chalice, the priest then places a piece of bread on the diskos next to the Lamb in remembrance of the Theotokos/Mother of God. Then pieces of bread are placed on the diskos (patten) in memory of St. John the Baptist, the Prophets, Apostles, Hierarchs, Martyrs, Monastic Saints, Healers and the whole company of the righteous with special mention of the Saints Commemorated on that particular day. Finally, a piece of bread is placed on the diskos in memory of the saint whose liturgy is being celebrated – St. John or St. Basil
- ✦ Additionally pieces of bread are placed on the diskos for the Bishop of the given church, the Hierarch who ordained the Clergyman, for all of the faithful both living and fallen asleep, once more with particular mention by name of those particularly remembered by the local community.
- ✦ The diskos and the chalice are then covered with special covers while the priest recites psalm 93 and other psalm verses with the offering of incense. The small dismissal and the benediction follows a prayer recited during the final part of the service, thus ending the service of the Prothesis.

- ◆ The prothesis is a rather late development in the history of the Divine Liturgy. It signifies the gathering of the entire Church of God into One Great Assembly: Christ the Head, together with the Theotokos and all the members of His Body, those already Glorified with Him in the Presence of the Father, together with all of the faithful disciples on earth. The Prothesis clearly shows that the Eucharistic Liturgy is always the action of the entire Church, with its head as Jesus Christ, and is always offered *“on behalf of all and for all.”*